championship and then decimating a full-strength Australian side in a short, pre-Cup ODI series.

The warning signals had been sent to the rest of the cricketing world. In Shubman Gill—the highest run-scorer for India in ODIs this calendar year—India has one of the most talented young batters in world cricket. His breathtaking stroke-play aside, the 24-year old's ability to translate good starts into substantial knocks is ample proof that he has a head mature beyond his years. Captain Rohit Sharma, fresh from scaling Mount 10K in one-day cricket, seems to have finally found the balance he'd been searching for between attack and defence—an approach that saw him finish with the best strike rate amongst the top six run-getters in the Asia Cup.

If anyone ever doubted Virat, the Delhi superjock served a timely reminder of his ODI prowess by smashing a match-winning century in a crunch game against Pakistan. That he's now just two centuries short of Sachin Tendulkar's all-time ODI record of 49 tons should be enough to fuel his fire ahead of the Cup. K.L. Rahul has risen again like the proverbial phoenix. Down and out after a serious back injury, the makeshift wicket-keeper cum middle-order bat has reclaimed his spot in the Indian starting XI. His jaw-dropping batting average of 93 since his return, coupled with the fact that he has been keeping wickets in all the matches—embellished with some stunning catches and showing no signs of his injury—has helped India in more ways than one. Hardik Pandya the batter was never the worry. Hardik Pandya the T20 bowler had been a certified asset too. But the jury was still out on Hardik Pandya the ODI bowler. The Asia Cup, though, delivered an emphatic verdict: the sheer pace and control with which the vice-captain bowled was befitting of a full-time ODI bowler and not the sixth bowling option he was often viewed as.

Indeed, India's bowling unit, too, has emerged as the talk of the town. Bumrah is bowling like he'd never been away from international cricket, dismissing top-order batters by using a combination of sheer pace and smart setups, just as he had done before his 11-month-long injury

THAT OUR BATTERS ARE FIRING ON ALL CYLINDERS COULD BE THE X-FACTOR IN INDIA'S QUEST TO LIFT THE 2023 WORLD CUP

PLAYERS TO WATCH OUT FOR

SHUBMAN GILL
INDIA
Gill makes his ODI World Cup debut having been the highest run-scorer in ODIs in 2023. His exploits as an opener may well decide India's campaign



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MITCHELL MARSH
AUSTRALIA
An impact player with both bat and ball, Marsh may open for Australia. Named as the next T20I captain, the World Cup will be his chance to justify that decision

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